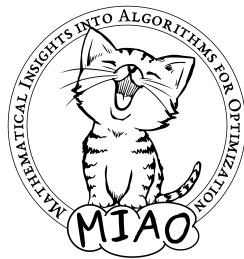


Tutorial on Mixed Integer Linear Programming (MIP) and Pseudo-Boolean Optimization

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*1st International Workshop on
Solving Linear Optimization Problems
for Pseudo-Booleans and Yonder*
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Outline of Tutorial on MIP Solving and PB Optimization

1 Mixed Integer Linear Programming (MIP)

- MIP Preliminaries
- Branch-and-Bound and Branch-and-Cut
- Additional Techniques

2 Combining PB and MIP Techniques

- Some Challenges When Integrating PB and LP Solving
- A Proof-of-Concept Hybrid PB-LP Solver
- Evaluation and Conclusions

An Acknowledgement and an Apology

The MIP material relies heavily on the presentation *Computational Mixed-Integer Programming* by *Ambros Gleixner* at the Casa Matemática Oaxaca (CMO) workshop *Theory and Practice of Satisfiability Solving* in 2018 (<https://tinyurl.com/MIPtutorial>)

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Another excellent source of resources are the webpages from the summer school *Computational Optimization at Work* in 2024 (<https://co-at-work.zib.de>)

Mixed Integer Linear Programming

Mixed integer linear program

- Minimize $\sum_j a_j x_j$
- Subject to $\sum_j a_{i,j} x_j \leq A_i, i = 1, \dots, m$
- $x_j \in \mathbb{N}$ for $j = 1, \dots, n$
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- Integer-valued variables
- Real-valued variables
- Linear objective function

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- No real-valued variables:
integer linear program (ILP)
- $0 \leq x_j \leq 1$ for all j : 0-1 ILP
- Vacuous objective $\sum_j 0 \cdot x_j$: decision problem
- But MIP makes most sense for optimization

Two Differences Compared to SAT/PB

Academia vs. industry

- Best solvers are commercial and closed-source
- E.g., CPLEX [CPL] (historically), GUROBI [Gur], and FICO XPress [FIC]
- Academic solvers like SCIP [SCI] and HiGHS [HiG] are excellent but not as good

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Search vs. backtracking

- SAT/PB: Fast decisions; careful, slow(er) conflict analysis
- MIP: Lots of time & effort on decisions; backtracking not so advanced

MIP Solving at a High Level

- ① Preprocessing (called **presolving**)
- ② Linear programming + **branch-and-bound**
- ③ Add **cutting planes** ruling out infeasible LP-solutions
(**branch-and-cut** method going back to [Gom58])
- ④ Heuristics for quickly finding good feasible solutions

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Far from exhaustive list. . .

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- Fast to solve (just linear programming)
 - LP solution x^* yields lower bound
 - Or, if x^* “accidentally” feasible, have optimal solution
 - Use simplex algorithm
 - many LP calls for same problem with different variable bounds
 - need efficient hot restarts

LP-Based Branch-and-Bound

Branch-and-bound

Choose integer-valued x_j and $B \in \mathbb{N}$

- Solve MIP plus constraint $x_j \geq B$
- Solve MIP plus constraint $x_j \leq B - 1$

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Prune subproblem/node when

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Branch on

- Variables
- General linear constraints (powerful but difficult)
Corresponds to **stabbing planes** proof system [BFI⁺18]

Branch-and-Cut

General cutting plane method

- ① Solve LP relaxation
- ② If solution x^* feasible for MIP $\Rightarrow$ found optimum
- ③ Otherwise generate and add constraint $\sum_j b_j x_j \leq B$ that is
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 - violated by LP solution x^*
- ④ Repeat from the top

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Branch-and-cut

- Run branch-and-bound
- But in each subproblem, use cutting plane method to repeatedly solve LP relaxation and add cut

Example Cut 1: Knapsack Cover Cut

Given constraint

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for $x_j \in \{0, 1\}$ and $a_j, A \in \mathbb{N}^+$

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(In cutting planes proof system, weaken & divide $\sum_{j \in I} a_j \bar{x}_j \geq -A + \sum_{j \in I} a_j$ to get disjunctive clause $\sum_{j \in C} \bar{x}_j \geq 1$)

Example Cut 2: Mixed Integer Rounding (MIR) Cut

Mixed integer rounding (MIR) cut [MW01] applied to (normalized) pseudo-Boolean constraint

$$\sum_i a_i \ell_i \geq A$$

with divisor $d \in \mathbb{N}^+$ produces constraint

$$\sum_i \left(\min(a_i \bmod d, A \bmod d) + \left\lfloor \frac{a_i}{d} \right\rfloor (A \bmod d) \right) \ell_i \geq \left\lceil \frac{A}{d} \right\rceil (A \bmod d)$$

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Concretely, MIR cut with divisor 3 applied on

$$x + 2y + 3z + 4w + 5u \geq 5$$

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For comparison, division by 3 and multiplication by 2 produces

$$2x + 2y + 2z + 4w + 4u \geq 4$$

Presolving

Presolving is a topic for a full separate lecture or two
(well, like most other aspects of MIP solving that we touch on. . .)

Important for performance (but not quite as important as in CDCL SAT solving?)

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Some simple (but efficient) techniques:

- **Substitution** of fixed variables
- **Normalization** of constraints: divide integer constraints by gcd on left-hand side and round on right-hand side
- **Probing**: tentatively assign binary variables and propagate
- **Dominance test**: remove constraints implied by other constraints

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MIP Conflict Analysis

MIP conflict analysis [Ach07] analogous to CDCL, but

- operate on clausal reasons extracted from constraints
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Perhaps a bit stupid example—solved immediately, since LP relaxation is infeasible. . .

But can find other, more interesting benchmarks where MIP conflict analysis seems to really suffer from this problem [DGN21]

Branching Heuristics

Dual gain

Given LP solution x^* , branch on x_j such that $x_j \geq \lceil x_j^* \rceil$ and $x_j \leq \lfloor x_j^* \rfloor$ both provide good lower bound increase

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Look ahead (strong branching)

- Consider all free variables x_j
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Keep also other statistics about variables to guide search

Node Selection

How to grow search tree?

- **Depth-first search (DFS)**: keeps cost for simplex calls small
*[corresponds to what SAT and PB solvers **always** do]*
- **Best bound search (BBS)**: Focus on improving lower bound
(dual bound)
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Combine BBS and BES with **DFS plunges** to exploit simplex hot restarts

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Example: Relaxation-enforced neighbourhood search

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Example of “fix-and-MIP” local neighbourhood search heuristic
(Note that, interestingly, this turns ILP into 0-1 ILP subproblem)

And More...

① Decomposition

- Branch-and-price / column generation
- Benders decomposition

[Core-guided and IHS search similar in spirit to logic-based Benders decomposition [HO03]]

② Symmetry handling

- Via graph automorphism
- Or dedicated symmetry detection (commercial solvers)

③ Extended formulations (with new variables and constraints)

④ Parallelization

⑤ Restarts

Numerics and Correctness

Numerics

- Use floating point for efficiency reasons
- Can lead to rounding errors
- Exact MIP solvers like [CKSW13, EG23]
 - are significantly slower
 - don't support the full range of state-of-the-art techniques

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Proof logging / certification

- Currently not available for state-of-the-art MIP solvers
- Though known that even best commercial solvers sometimes give wrong results
- Some work on proof logging in [CGS17, EG23] — challenges:
 - How to capture wide diversity of techniques?
 - What is a convenient format?
 - How to generate proofs efficiently on-the-fly?

Some Interesting MIP Questions

- 1 Develop better heuristics to branch on general linear constraints
(cf. **stabbing planes** [BFI⁺18])
- 2 Design stronger conflict analysis operating directly on linear constraints
(borrowing ideas from native pseudo-Boolean solvers)
[Recent work [MBGN23, MSB⁺25]]
- 3 Provide rigorous understanding of MIP solver performance
- 4 Develop families of theory benchmarks and computational complexity results for them (cf. interaction between SAT solving and proof complexity [BN21])
- 5 Steal pseudo-Boolean proof logging ideas and techniques and use for MIP solving
[Recent work [DEGH23, HOGN24]]
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[Next and final topic]

Combining Pseudo-Boolean Solving and Mixed Integer Programming

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- Sometimes terrible performance even when LP relaxation infeasible [EGNV18]

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Why not merge the two to get the best of both worlds of pseudo-Boolean conflict-driven search and MIP-style branch-and-cut?

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Need to **carefully balance time allocation** for PB solver and LP solver

Backtracking from LP Infeasibility?

What to do if LP solver call shows LP relaxation infeasible under current trail?

- Obviously, PB solver should backtrack
- But can only do conflict analysis on violated pseudo-Boolean constraint
- And PB solver blissfully unaware of any conflict. . .

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More subtle issue:

- Efficient LP solvers use inexact floating-point arithmetic
- How to incorporate LP solver inferences into Boolean solver that must maintain perfectly sound reasoning?

Sharing of Cut Constraints?

Cut constraints from LP solver

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Cut constraints from PB solver

- Pseudo-Boolean solvers learn new constraints at high rate from conflict analysis
- These learned constraints can also be viewed as cuts
- Should such constraints be passed from PB solver to LP solver?
- Maybe when a solution to the LP violates a constraint learned on the PB side?

Report on Proof-of-Concept PB-LP Integration [DGN21]

- ① Interleave LP solving within conflict-driven PB search
 - Limit LP time by enforcing **total #LP pivots $\leq$ #PB conflicts**
 - Only run LP solver when this condition holds
 - **Abort if $> P$ pivots in single LP call**; but if so also double limit P to avoid wasted LP calls in future

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 - Use this **Farkas constraint** as starting point for conflict analysis
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- ③ When LP solver finds solution to LP relaxation
 - Generate MIP-style Gomory cut
 - Share constraint to tighten search space on both PB and LP side
 - Try to use LP solution to guide PB search (e.g., variable decisions)

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 - Limit LP time by enforcing **total #LP pivots $\leq$ #PB conflicts**
 - Only run LP solver when this condition holds
 - **Abort if $> P$ pivots in single LP call**; but if so also double limit P to avoid wasted LP calls in future
- ② When LP solver detects that LP relaxation infeasible
 - **Farkas' lemma** $\Rightarrow$ violated linear combination of constraints
 - Use this **Farkas constraint** as starting point for conflict analysis
 - Computed using exact arithmetic, so no rounding errors
 - But might not be violated — if so, ignore and continue PB search
- ③ When LP solver finds solution to LP relaxation
 - Generate MIP-style Gomory cut
 - Share constraint to tighten search space on both PB and LP side
 - Try to use LP solution to guide PB search (e.g., variable decisions)
- ④ Also explore letting PB solver pass learned constraints to LP solver

(What We Need from) Farkas Lemma [Far02]

Pseudo-Boolean Farkas Lemma

Given

- Pseudo-Boolean formula $F = \{C_1, \dots, C_m\}$,
- partial assignment ρ ,

such that LP relaxation of residual formula $F|_{\rho}$ infeasible

Then $\exists$ coefficients $k_i \in \mathbb{N}$ such that linear combination

$$\sum_{i=1}^m k_i \cdot C_i$$

is violated by ρ , i.e.,

$$\text{slack}(\sum_{i=1}^m k_i \cdot C_i; \rho) < 0$$

Observed in [MM04] that $\sum_{i=1}^m k_i \cdot C_i$ is valid starting point for PB conflict analysis

Relation to MIP Solvers with Conflict Analysis?

MIP solvers also combine constraint propagation and SAT-style clause learning with LP solving

- Implemented in SCIP [ABKW08]
- And also in closed-source solvers (see [AW13])

Important to understand similarities and differences — let's give high-level description of PB search and conflict analysis phrased in MIP language

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Pseudo-Boolean search

- 1 Make **decision** to assign free variable to 0 or 1
- 2 **Propagate** all assignments implied by some linear constraint until saturation
- 3 If no contradiction, go to step 1
- 4 Otherwise some constraint C violated $\Rightarrow$ trigger **conflict analysis**

PB Conflict Analysis “in MIP Language”

Pseudo-Boolean conflict analysis (simplified description)

- 1 Find **reason constraint** R responsible for propagating last variable x in violated constraint C to “wrong value”

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- 7 Switch back to **search** phase

Comparison to MIP Propagation and Conflict Analysis

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- Instead use disjunctive clauses extracted from reason constraints via conflict graph
- Incurs exponential loss in power compared to operating on actual linear constraints (follows from [BKS04, CCT87, Hak85])

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Arithmetic

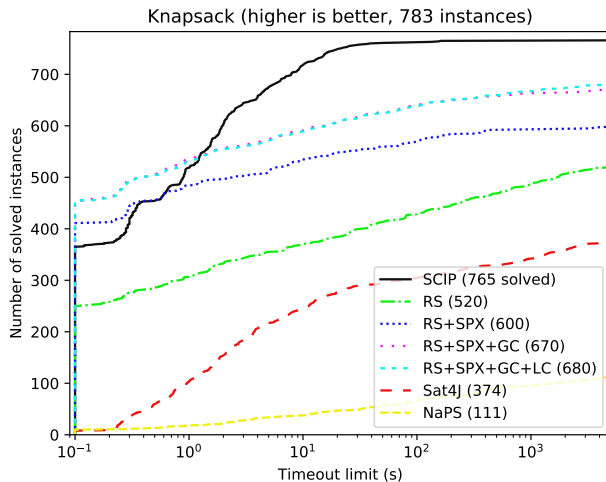
- SCIP uses floating point
- Reasoning steps in pseudo-Boolean solver computed with exact integer arithmetic
- No issues with possible rounding errors

Experimental Results for Knapsack Benchmarks [Pis05]

ROUNDINGSAT (RS) enhanced with

- LP solver SoPLeX (SPX)
(from SCIP)
- Gomory cuts (GC)
- shared learned PB cuts (LC)

compared to other solvers



Experimental Results for PB and MIPLIB Benchmarks

ROUNDINGSAT (RS) run on PB and 0-1 ILP instances with

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	SCIP	RS	+SPX	+GC	+LC	SAT4J	NAPS
PB16dec (1783)	1123	1472	1453	1452	1451	1432	1400
PB16opt (1600)	1057	862	988	986	993	776	896
MIPdec (556)	264	203	263	261	259	169	170
MIPopt (291)	125	78	101	102	102	62	65

Performance of Integrated PB-LP Solver

- ① Best of both worlds?
 - At least well-rounded performance
 - Hybrid PB-LP solver always competitive with best solver
 - Pretty dramatic improvements for optimization problems compared to pseudo-Boolean state of the art
 - SCIP is hard to beat, but also pulls quite a few extra tricks that we haven't implemented (like problem-type-specific approaches)

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- ③ Sharing Gomory cuts and learned cuts not so helpful
 - Except for knapsack benchmarks, where they help a lot
 - And maybe we could/should fine-tune how sharing is done?

Usefulness/Usage of Constraints

Estimate usefulness of different types of constraints

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Constraints learned after Farkas-based conflicts

- Less useful than regular learned constraints
- But big spread in usage measurements

Pseudo-Boolean Solver Performance: Balancing the Picture

To provide fuller view, should also be mentioned that `ROUNDINGSAT` can outperform commercial MIP solvers by 1-2 orders of magnitude for problems such as, e.g.,

- matching of children with adoptive families [DGG⁺19]
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ROUNDINGSAT seems particularly good for “big- M constraints” like

$$A\bar{z} + \sum_i a_i \ell_i \geq A$$

encoding $z \Rightarrow \sum_i a_i \ell_i \geq A$

Coefficient A of $\bar{z}$ can be very large compared to a_i 's $\Rightarrow$ LP relaxation quite uninformative

Future Research Directions for PB-LP Integration (1/2)

① Fine-tune heuristics

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- Smarter sharing of PB constraints with LP solver?
- Dynamic allocation of PB and LP solving time based on contributions?

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- ⑤ Use MIR cuts and/or other MIP cut rules to improve conflict analysis
[MBGN23, MSB⁺25]

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[Ongoing work in [MBGN23, MSB⁺25]]

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[Ongoing work in [MBGN23, MSB⁺25]]
- ⑨ Develop hybrid PB-LP solver to solve 0-1 MIP problems à la Benders
 - PB solver decides on Boolean variables and propagates
 - LP solver takes care of real-valued variables

Take-Away Message (for This and the Other Tutorials)

- Revolution in performance last two decades in
 - Boolean satisfiability (SAT) solving
 - Mixed integer linear programming (MIP)
- More recent addition: Cutting-planes-based pseudo-Boolean conflict-driven search
- Quite different approaches
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Thanks for sticking till the end!

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